of the caste affiliations of the authors? Would our responses to the stories themselves be any different had they been published without that qualifier?

All regardless, this is a must-read collection. People who claim to hate SF need to overcome their prejudices and take the plunge.

Frankly, it's a little ridiculous to even make a distinction between spec-fiction and the ordinary kind these days. In every real sense, we live in a multiverse of layered time-zones and embattled technologies. We Indians, in particular, have become cultural chimeras: we have Asian hearts, British language and American business practices but the claws and poison sacs of ancient prejudice.

The stories are as texturally varied as the accents at a UN Conference. Nabi H. Ali's 'Melonhead' for instance, is a warm and conventionally well-structured story in which two variations of Islam get help from a djinn. In Gautam Vegda's four brief fables, vultures are de-formed, reformed and regurgitated through the author's ruthless vision of cruelty and injustice.

In Yeswanth Morchala's 'Looly Cooly' collage-graphic images are stitched together to make a cheekily funny-bitter comic. In Bakarmax's 'Spacewali', Indian astronauts beam up their sweeper-lady as well as their ancient prejudices about the division of labour. In Archita Mittra's 'Happily Ever After', two young women escape into a sweet-sad paradise of their own making, by snatching a magical victory out of the fire of hate that surrounds them.

'Margin Mag', by Sudarshan Devadoss and M.K. Abhilash, is a Monty-Pythonesque e-zine, revealing the spirit in which the book may have been conceived. R.T. Samuel's 'Introduction' offers a clear and well-reasoned rationale for how and why the book came into being. It's a great standalone essay about SF in South Asia and a sharp critique of existing Indian SF publications and authors.

Along with caste-based intolerance, **GENDER-BASED INJUSTICE**, power differentials and raw hypocrisy share the stage in these stories

Samuel quotes Sant Ravidas, "a radical anti-caste thinker and poet" of the 14th century, writing of a utopia called "Begumpura". While enjoying the poem, I had believed in my ignorance, that the name referred to a woman, i.e., a 'Begum'. But a friend with whom I shared the poem immediately deconstructed it as "be-*gum*", meaning "without pain".

It was a tiny reminder of the many ways in which books, words and titles punch open the windows of our perceptions. ■

–Manjula Padmanabhan



named Nila is approached to fight Jagat's case and prove his innocence–even if that innocence proves to be a powder keg for Peruma's hard-fought peace.

First, the good stuff. This is a premise with undeniable potential–a legal thriller and a political allegory wrapped lovingly with genre beats. Bhatia, a lawyer, is very good on the absurdities of realpolitik (Peruma's peace is accompanied by the aptly named 'Pact of Forgetting') or ideas at the intersection of politics and morality. The nods to Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* are also enjoyable, for the most part. For example, in Asimov's fictional science of psychohistory, pivotal moments in history are called "inflection points", something borrowed by Bhatia wholesale–he attributes the nomenclature to the fictional "D.D. Mausambi", a humorous allusion ('mausambi' is 'sweet lime' in Hindi) to the Indian mathematician-historian D.D. Kosambi (1907-1966).

The novel is a legal thriller and political allegory wrapped with genre beats. Bhatia is very good on the absurdities of realpolitik

However, good novels are unruly, many-eyed creatures, filled with several distinct kinds of writing. And Bhatia hasn't got the hang of writing dialogue just yet. Nila swings between being a reserved protagonist and delivering cloyingly poetic lines. Maru, her best friend, could have been replaced by a TV voiceover because his primary purpose seems to be "plot-recapper". These issues were far less prominent in Bhatia's previous novel *The Wall*, but this could have done with a firmer editorial hand. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha